

Niri Window + Steam Fullscreen Field Guide

CachyOS // Niri // Noctalia v5

MOD+F	Bar-aware maximize
MOD+SHIFT+F	True fullscreen toggle
STEAM GAMES	True fullscreen above the bar

PURPOSE

Keep ordinary applications maximized inside Niri's usable workspace, stopping cleanly beneath the Noctalia bar, while allowing games to occupy the entire display during play.

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01 // BAR-AWARE MAXIMIZE

Requested behavior

Pressing **Mod+F** should keep the focused application windowed, expand it across the screen width, and extend its height only to the bottom edge of the top bar.

Edit the Niri keybind

Open `~/.config/niri/config.kdl`. Inside the existing `binds { }` block, replace any fullscreen action currently assigned to **Mod+F** with:

```
Mod+F { maximize-column; }
Mod+Shift+F { fullscreen-window; }
```

Expected result

Mod+F toggles a maximized column within the usable workspace. **Mod+Shift+F** remains available for genuine fullscreen. Niri normally reloads a valid configuration automatically after saving.

Noctalia requirement

In **Noctalia Settings - Bar - Layout - Advanced**, enable **Reserve space**. This creates the compositor exclusive zone that tells Niri where the bar ends and the application workspace begins.

```
Reserve space: Enabled
Layer: Top
```

If the window still slides underneath the bar

1. Confirm the bar's Reserve space setting is enabled.
2. Confirm the bar is attached to the same monitor as the window.
3. Confirm **Mod+F** calls `maximize-column`, not `fullscreen-window`.
4. Save the configuration again and retry with a normal tiled window.

ROLLBACK

```
Restore your former Mod+F line in config.kdl. No package removal or system rollback is required.
```

02 // TRUE FULLSCREEN GAMES

Requested behavior

Steam games should cover the complete display, including the Noctalia bar area, while normal desktop windows continue to respect the bar.

Preferred setup

In each game's video or display settings, select **Fullscreen** or **Exclusive Fullscreen**. Avoid Borderless Windowed when the goal is compositor-level true fullscreen. Most games will request fullscreen from Niri without an extra rule.

Noctalia bar layer

Keep the bar on the **Top** layer. A Top-layer bar yields to a fullscreen application; an Overlay-layer bar is specifically allowed to appear above fullscreen applications.

Optional Niri rule for Steam/XWayland games

Add the following as a top-level block in `~/.config/niri/config.kdl` - outside the binds block - only if games repeatedly launch windowed:

```
window-rule {  
    match app-id=r#"^steam_app_[0-9]+$"  
    open-fullscreen true  
}
```

Important limitation

The rule matches the common XWayland Steam application ID format. Native Wayland games may expose a different application ID and therefore may need an individual rule. Do not match the Steam client itself, or the whole client may open fullscreen.

Manual fallback

Focus the game and press **Mod+Shift+F**. This invokes Niri's true fullscreen action directly and should cover the bar area.

03 // FINAL CONFIG + CHECKLIST

Recommended Niri excerpt

```
binds {
  Mod+F { maximize-column; }
  Mod+Shift+F { fullscreen-window; }
}

window-rule {
  match app-id=r#"^steam_app_[0-9]+$"#
  open-fullscreen true
}
```

Verification sequence

STEP	TEST	PASS CONDITION
1	Open Firefox or Kitty and press Mod+F.	Window fills usable width and stops below the bar.
2	Press Mod+F again.	Previous column width is restored.
3	Launch a Steam game set to Fullscreen.	Game covers the entire display and the bar is hidden behind it.
4	Exit the game or leave fullscreen.	Noctalia bar returns and ordinary windows still respect it.

Troubleshooting notes

If only one game misbehaves, first change that game's display mode and restart it. If the bar remains above every fullscreen game, recheck that Noctalia's layer is **Top**, not **Overlay**. If a native Wayland game ignores the optional rule, identify its actual app ID and create a narrowly matched rule for that title.

REFERENCES

Niri Window Rules: <https://niri-wm.github.io/niri/Configuration:-Window-Rules.html>
Noctalia Bar: <https://docs.noctalia.dev/noctalia/bar/>